ADL Research Reflect Reform

# Research Report

## NRI Employee Research

UAE Representative Offices

Survey & Interviews

by **Rhituja Shende**

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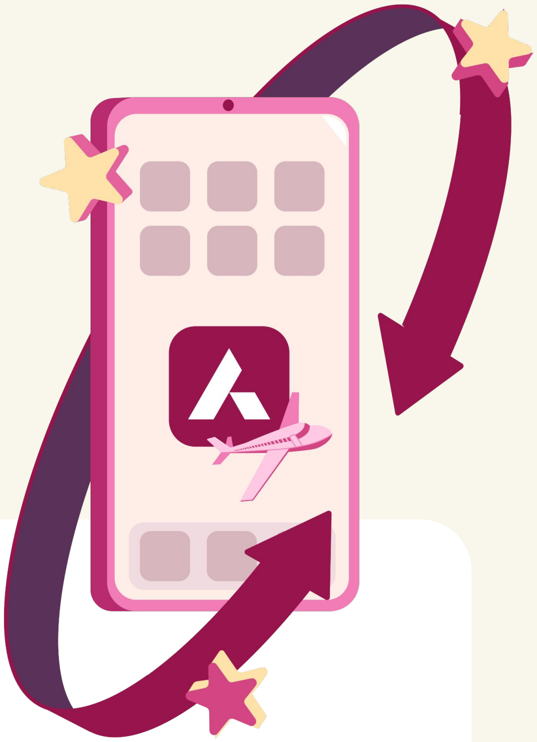
Background

# Revamping the NRI Banking Experience



# About Qualitative Research

Qualitative research (like this study) explores subjective experiences to understand the ‘what’, ‘how’ and ‘why’.

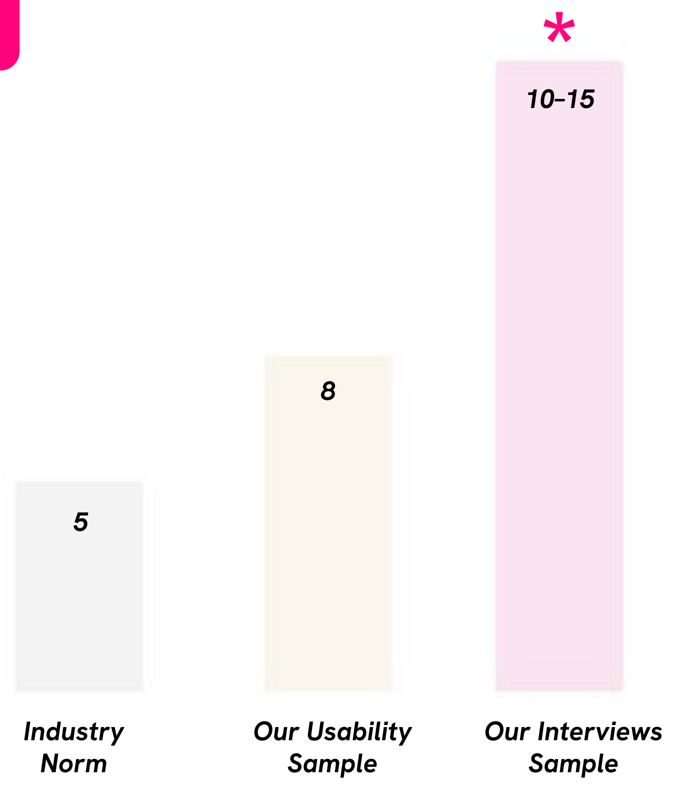
| | QUALITATIVE RESEARCH | QUANTITATIVE RESEARCH |
|---|---|---|
| **Best for learning** | -What do users...?<br>-How do users...?<br>-Why do users...? | -How many users...?<br>-How much...? |
| **Sample Size** | -10 to 15 users | -100s and 1000s of users |
| **Statistical significance** | -No | -Yes |

# Sample Size in Qualitative Research

The industry norm for a usability test is to start with 5 participants.

However since our cohorts at Axis are often complex, we observe that we should start with 8 participants.

**In the case of interviews, we observe that findings start getting saturated/ repetitive after 10-15 participants.**




***Qualitative Studies ≠ How Many***

*Reference: Nielsen Norman Group*

# Research Goal

Understand the NRI banking experience from the lens of frontline staff at Axis Bank's UAE Representative Offices (Abu Dhabi, Dubai, Sharjah)

1. To understand NRI users' experience with Axis Bank
2. To identify the products & services that NRIs need most assistance with and understand reasons for each
3. To understand the employee's experience with NRI banking

# User Profile and methodology

- Participants were employees from the Axis Bank Representative Office in the UAE.
  - Survey (77 responses)
  - 45–60 mins interview each with 11 employees

| Participant | Grade | Office |
|---|---|---|
| P1 | Senior Manager | Abu Dhabi |
| P2 | Senior Manager | Abu Dhabi |
| P3 | Senior Manager | Dubai |
| P4 | Deputy Manager | Sharjah |
| P5 | Senior Manager | Dubai |
| P6 | Manager | Sharjah |
| P7 | AVP | Dubai |
| P8 | Assistant Manager | Dubai |
| P9 | Senior Manager | Abu Dhabi |
| P10 | Senior Manager | Dubai |
| P11 | AVP | Abu Dhabi |

# The NRI Lifecycle

# The NRI Lifecycle


The employees observe users coming from four phases in the NRI lifecycle with each phase having a distinct set of financial goals and behaviours.

# *The NRI Lifecycle Archetypes* *1/2*

## 1. NEW TO NRI

**PROFILE**
Often younger in age and hence highly tech-savvy but they might not be banking-savvy.

**GOAL**
To familiarise and restructure financial footprint as per guidelines.

**BEHAVIOUR**
Tend to enquire extensively in the initial months.


## 2. SETTLING NRI

**PROFILE**
A mix of upcoming HNIs and Blue-Collar members.

**GOAL**
To close pending liabilities asap and begin wealth accumulation.

**BEHAVIOUR**
Tend to expect preferential treatment due to NRI status.

# The NRI Lifecycle Archetypes



## 3. ESTABLISHED NRI

**PROFILE**
Often HNIs and could be arriving cusp of seniority.

**GOAL**
To diversify wealth.

**BEHAVIOUR**
Tend to connect with multiple banks for best offerings as per goal.

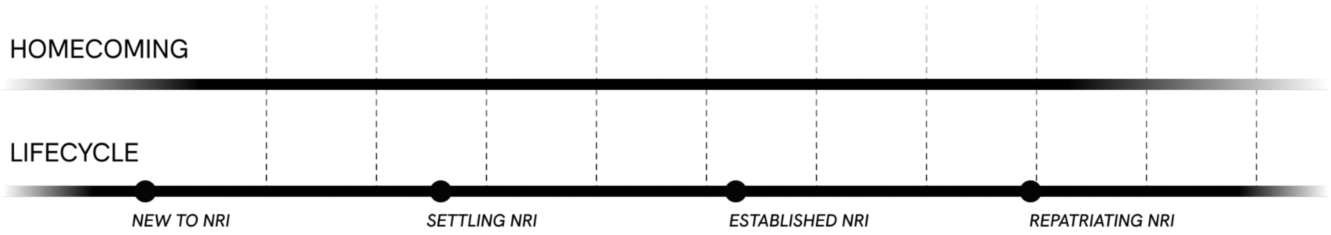
## 4. REPATRIATING NRI

**PROFILE**
Often HNIs and senior citizens.

**GOAL**
To streamline finances to reduce maintenance efforts.

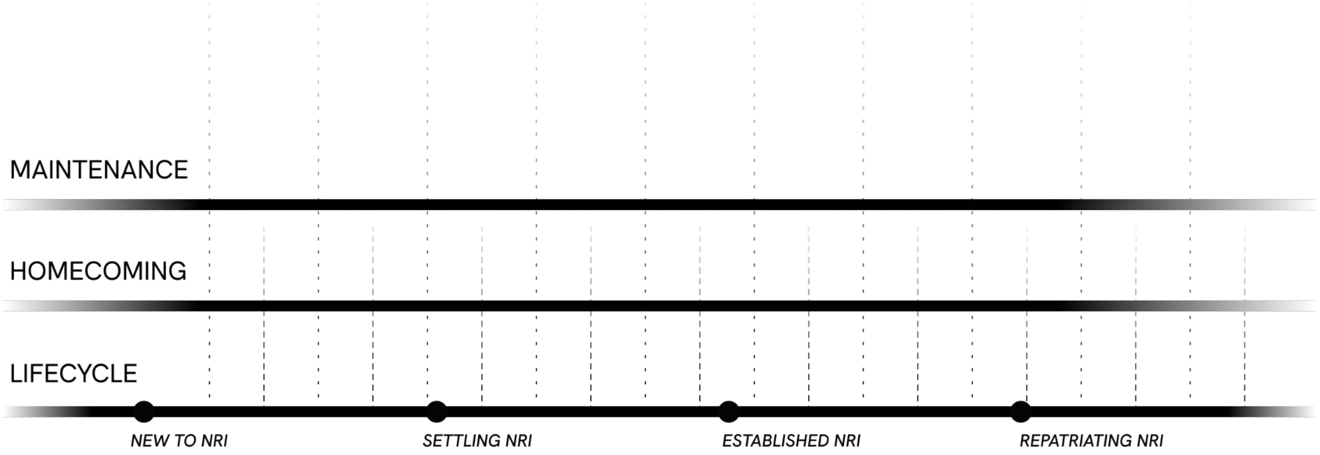
**BEHAVIOUR**
Tend to consolidate finances and close relationships no longer needed.

# The NRI Lifecycle




While NRI users transition through the general lifecycle, there’s a homecoming loop that runs parallel to it.

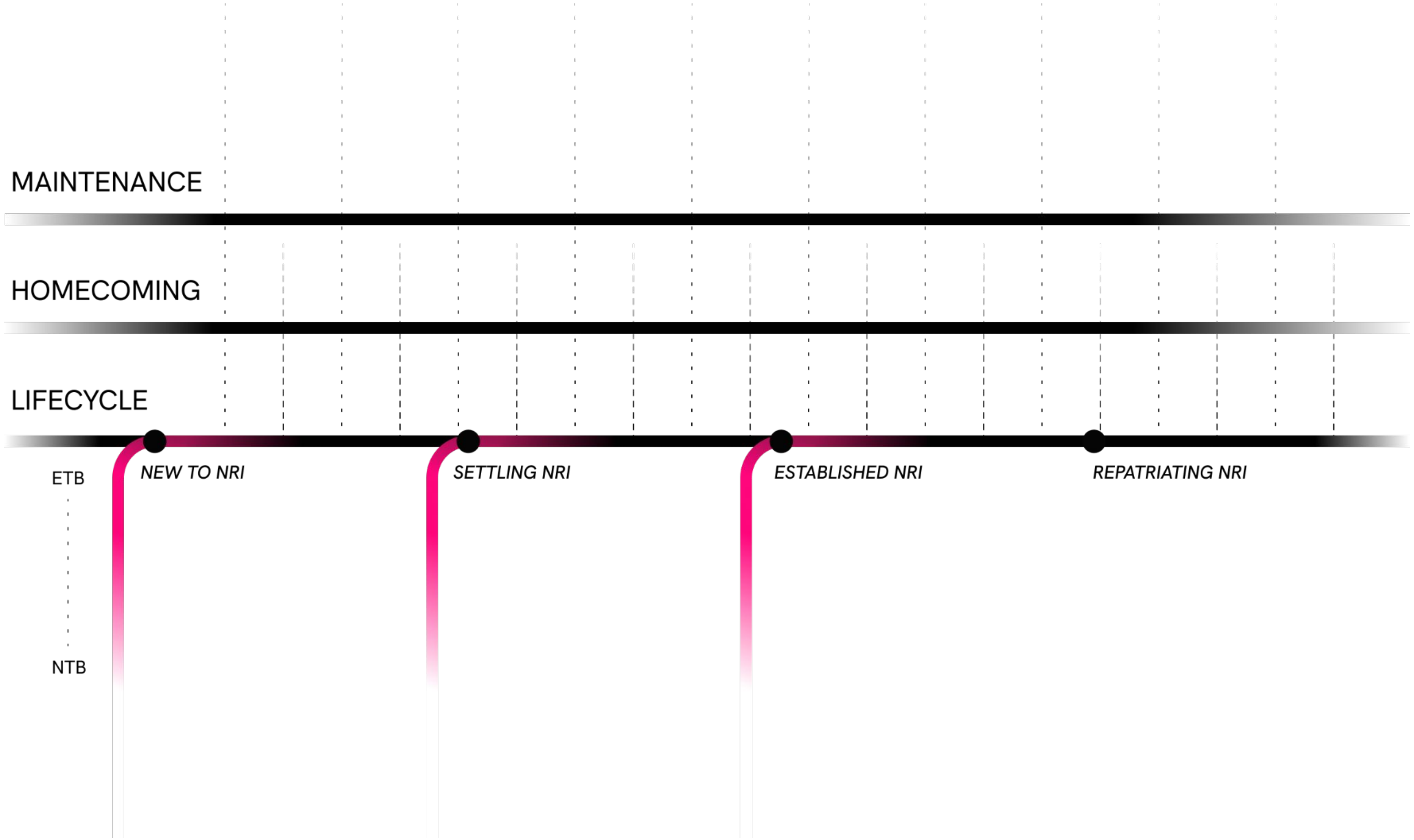
# The NRI Lifecycle



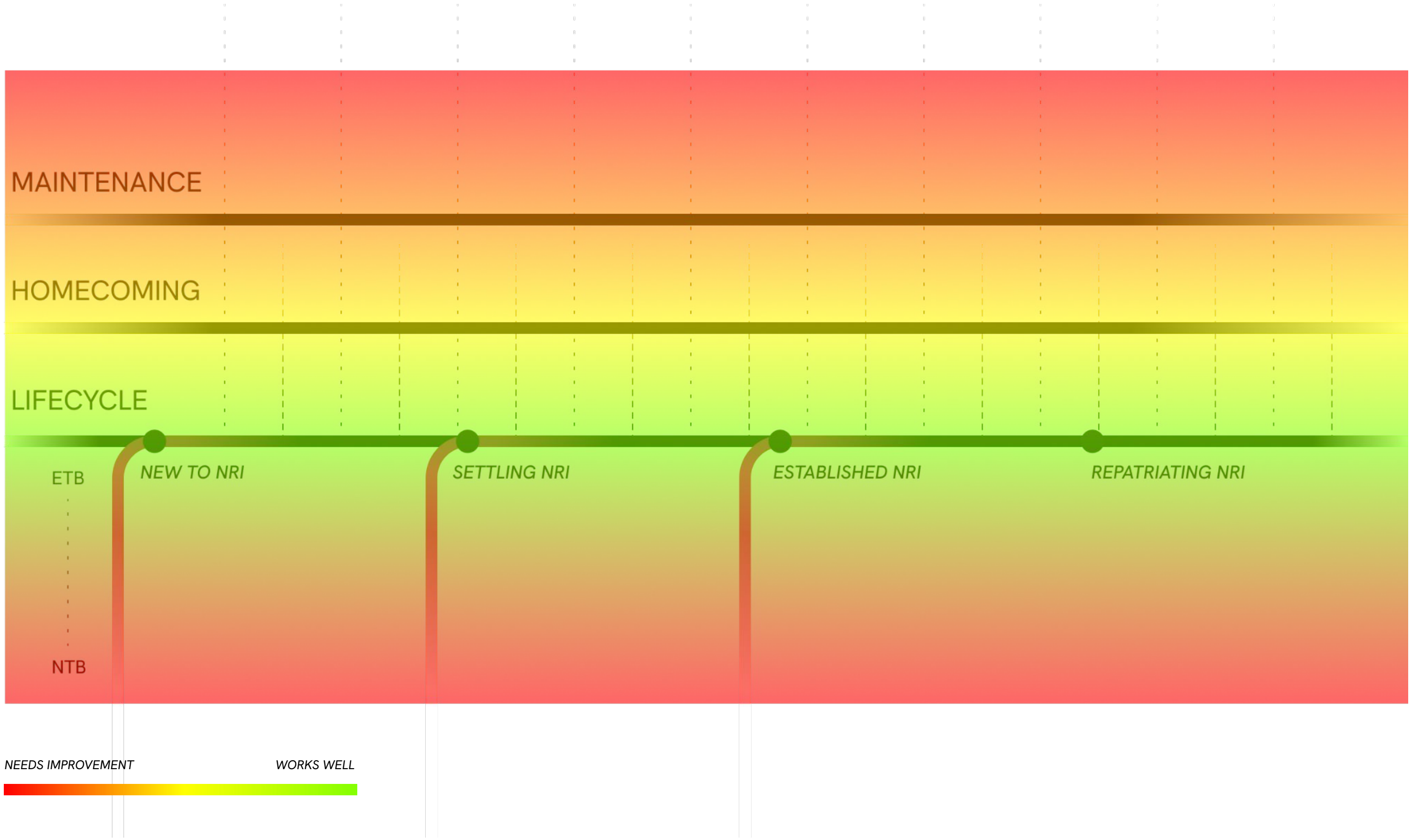

Finally, there's the 'maintenance' layer that also runs parallel to the others and involves the upkeep of all banking relationships a user has.

# Axis Bank NRI Experience

# Where Axis Bank Joins



# Snapshot: The Axis Bank NRI Experience



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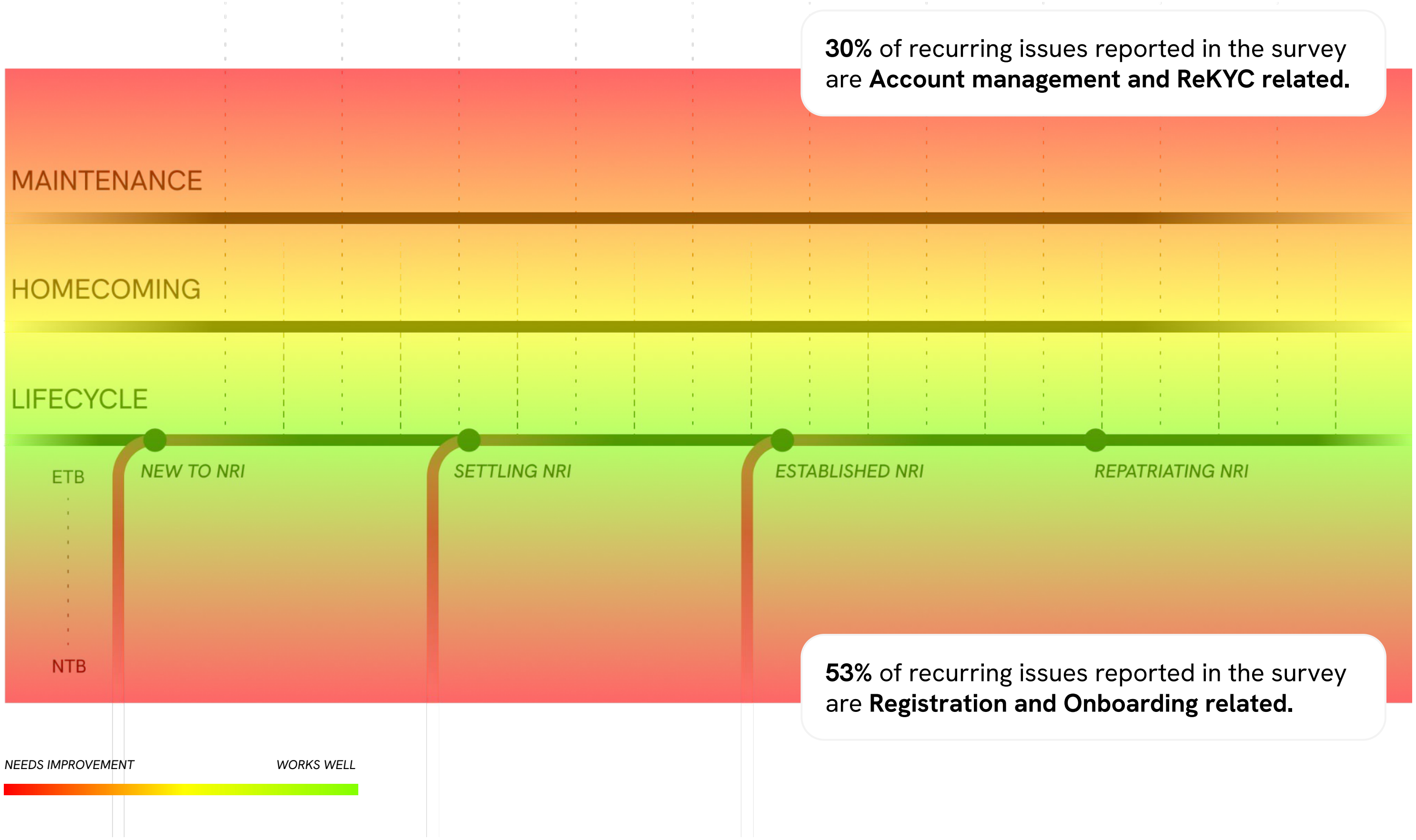



**30%** of recurring issues reported in the survey are **Account management and ReKYC related.**

**53%** of recurring issues reported in the survey are **Registration and Onboarding related.**

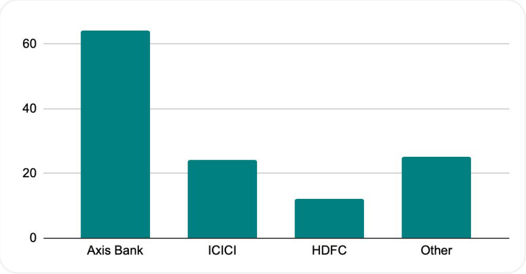
# Snapshot: The Axis Bank NRI Experience

| STATUS | PRODUCT | APP | SERVICE |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Working well** | **Robust Core Foundation**<br>Strong depth in traditional savings and high self-service transaction limits that empower mass-affluent users. | **Post-Onboarding Efficiency**<br>A seamless, highly reliable, and empowering interface for routine transactions and account visibility once the user is successfully onboarded. | **Relationship-Driven Trust**<br>High regional brand trust anchored by the willingness of local Rep Office staff to provide dedicated, hands-on support. |
| **Needs Improvement** | **Digital Gaps & Punitive Rules**<br>A lack of digital capabilities for basic updations & high-value tasks (FCNR, repatriation) coupled with rigid, context-blind compliance policies. | **Generic UX & Structural Friction**<br>Onboarding friction, one-for-all experience, and confusing information architecture after dashboard. | **Broken Backend Operations**<br>Paralyzing processing times, opaque resolutions, and inconsistent inter-branch coordination that shift massive, unnecessary manual burdens onto frontline staff. |

# Stage I: New to Bank

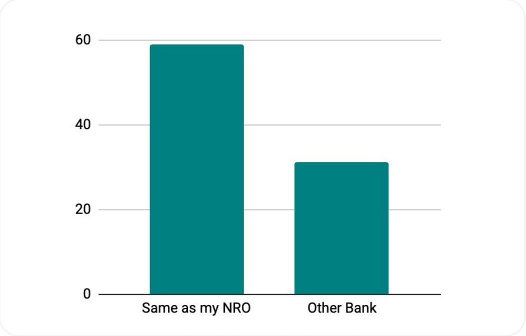
Users having good long term relationships (having a legacy account, investments) with their bank in India, prefer to continue those as primary accounts by simply converting them to NRI accounts.

**At Axis Bank, referrals is the dominant path to a new relationship.**




WHERE RESPONDENTS HOLD THEIR NRO ACCOUNT

- **‘New to NRI’ need immense patience and extensive guidance**
  - Becoming an NRI is a relocation event that lands the user with new compliance and guidelines they typically don't understand yet, while also juggling housing, a new SIM, and a new job.
- **‘Settling and Established NRI’ anticipate preferential treatment**
  - Users who have lived in the Gulf for a while often approach Indian banks with high expectations. They expect low minimum balances, and premium services simply because they are NRIs.




WHERE RESPONDENTS HOLD THEIR NRE ACCOUNT

# Registration & Onboarding



Registration is the first impression of the bank's digital experience. At Axis Bank, the **device verification (SIM binding) process** is the most significant hurdle for new users, **plagued by technical failures and a lack of clear communication, which creates anxiety and frustration.**

*"...there is a stage of mobile number verification. So most of customers are using two SIMs and they have one physical and Indian sim also. So the message is not going from the phone to the server... not from the registered SIM I think. So I will tell the customers sir uh you have to disable the SIM two or you maybe sometimes you have to remove the second SIM..."*

*- Deputy Manager, Sharjah*

**Reasons for SIM binding failures**

- Users having dual or e-sim, might choose the incorrect SIM.
    - Users having corporate SIMs (provided by employers) do not have international SMS facilities enabled.

- For devices without "auto-send", users miss pressing the "send" button in the narrow window leading to timeout.
    - Lack of clear communication confuses users unfamiliar with the process. They fear scam when they see the encrypted SMS and a random Indian number recipient.

# Registration & Onboarding 2/3

**The structural flow of the contradicts a user's mental model and demands unnecessary cognitive load.**

Local UAE banks leverage national digital infrastructure to make onboarding and compliance practically invisible.

### Drawbacks of process

- The "consent" and "registration" stage sequence needs to be relooked to avoid a back-and-forth loop.
- Redundant, manual data entry within the process as well as repeating the same for both MB & IB is cumbersome.
- Setting up five distinct security questions during initial onboarding feels tedious and customers are unable to recollect answers later.
- The CTA is not visible in the first fold and users have to scroll to locate it.


ABU DHABI COMMERCIAL BANK APP
ALLOWS LOGIN WITH UAE PASS

# Registration & Onboarding 3/3

An operational bottleneck occurs where strict physical address **compliance directly breaks** the digital onboarding experience, particularly **for dependents.**

*"...as per Axis bank policy we accept certain set of documents as a overseas address proof. But for the housewife, for minors, for the students, they will not be having those sort of address proof. I know it is not nice for us also to tell them to get new connection or plan, but we are still trying to advise those customers..."*
*- Senior Manager, Dubai*

**The experience of dependents**

- Dependents (housewives, minors, students) rarely have a valid overseas address proof in their own name which is a prerequisite for opening NRI account.
- The bank mandates using their Indian address due to which deliverables like the welcome kit are not received at the UAE address and the account can potentially freeze.
- To bypass this, RO staff are forced to suggest awkward workarounds, such as asking dependents to buy entirely new postpaid phone plans just to generate a valid "utility bill" in their name.

# Stage II: General Usage

As users start settling into dual-geography banking, their usage splits. Local banks become primary touchpoint for daily finances like payments, bills, and remittance (local banks have almost zero margins).

**Whereas Indian banks take a backseat and are used intermittently (~4 times a month) for specific needs like tracking finances, managing indian investments, and paying family's bills.**

- **Settling NRI**
  - Financially, this segment's primary focus is remitting money back to India to clear existing liabilities and loans.

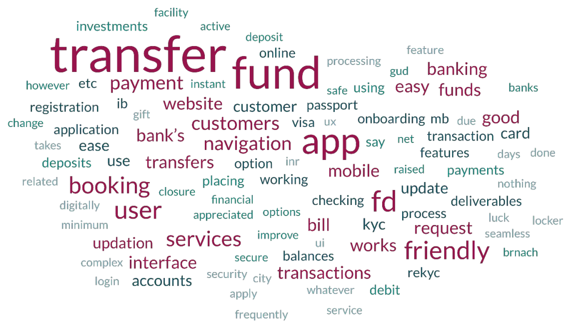
- **The Lower-Middle Strata**
  - This segment's (often laborers or blue-collar workers) primary focus is supporting their family in India and they often give the debit card to their family.
  - Their major need is to track the transactions and account balance but they face tech limitations, language barriers, and telecom constraints.
  - They use limited mobile-data packs which only allow access to few apps like WhatsApp and Facebook. Hence they have a preference for WhatsApp Banking.

# Digital Experience at Stage II (Wins) 1/2

**There's a "Post-Onboarding" relief**

**HIGH DASHBOARD EFFICIENCY**
Users get an excellent, consolidated snapshot of a their entire relationship in a single point. Essential, high-frequency options are presented immediately on the home screen, allowing users to perform core actions without digging through menus.

**AUTONOMOUS CONTROLS**
The app excels at giving users easy access and control over their accounts and security like managing their cards and limits.




**What employees hear working well in the app/ website**

**34%** hear about digital transaction capabilities
**22%** hear about interface and usability
**22%** hear about basic service accessibility

# Digital Experience at Stage II (Challenges) 2/2

## Offerings visible but inaccessible to NRIs create confusion

**ADD MONEY**
Options like "Add Money" are prominently displayed but do not functionally work for NRIs, leading to confusion when used.

**UPI**
Users receive UPI registration popup even though it is not currently supported at Axis Bank for international (UAE) mobile numbers.

## Architecture beyond dashboard feels misaligned

**SEARCH**
The universal search bar does not surface specific deep-linked tasks; searching "visa" does not bring up the "update visa" option unless the search bar inside 'Profile' is used.

**DEBIT CARD**
Related tasks are scattered. For example, PIN setup and managing card usage are not located in a single hub.

## Basic capability is missing in digital channels

**BROKEN WORKFLOWS**
Customers encounter persistent server errors or "ineligible" messages when attempting basic self-service tasks, such as account migration, account closure, downloading FD advice, updating signatures, and downloading interest certificates.

**INCLUSIVITY**
Elements like radio buttons for account selection during fund transfers are too dim and lack sufficient contrast for users with poor eyesight. Financial jargon, such as "intermediary" during outward remittances, causes hesitation and confusion.

# *Stage III: Wealth Accumulation*

At Axis Bank, routine usage or everyday transactions are fast, simple, and do what they promise. But **NRI accounts are not primarily used for these routine tasks.**

**As users begin transitioning from 'Settling' to 'Established' their focus shifts to wealth accumulation.** Users who have lived in the UAE for longer durations start looking into long-term wealth building, such as SIPs, Demat accounts, and Home Loans for purchasing properties in India.

**At this stage NRIs break away from their primary accounts. They compare and select the best product offerings across the market.**

- **The younger demographics**
    - This segment is most volatile and aggressively seeks the highest interest rates or returns to grow wealth quickly, often migrating to other banks if a better rate is offered.

# Digital Experience at Stage III

At Axis Bank, a recurring pattern is the presence of **UI elements that promise a capability but fail during execution** (without explanation), affecting user trust and forcing reliance on manual branch support.

- **Syncing Disconnects**
  - Deposits made via the app (such as GIFT city deposits) do not reflect on the front end, causing immediate anxiety for users regarding their funds.
- **Edge Case Oversights**
  - Joint account FD booking defaults to a "self" mode, which fails to accommodate the needs of joint bookings.

*"...certain options are there in the mobile app but it's not working...there is an option for account migration...yesterday I met a client who is maintaining the usable balances for like more than 3 months in his account and when we tried upgrading his account it was showing that both accounts are ineligible for that I don't know what the criteria but I check cross check to the system also but in mobile application it is not working..."*

*- Senior Manager, Dubai*

# Stage IV: Wealth Diversification

As wealth grows, users keep creating relationships across banks, partly for products/rates, and also as insurance. **In such cases the product offerings and availability of a branch abroad, are major deciding factors.**

Cross-border money movement is a core NRI use case. Competitor banks like ICICI have successfully digitized and centralised complex NRI and foreign currency processes, drastically reducing turnaround time (TAT) and removing the need for physical branch intervention.

**Hence dependency on offline processes leads to a risk of losing HNI clients and multimillion-dollar deals.**

*"...Anyone who has surplus funds in India, business income, property sale, their Indian mutual funds and Indian shares...These are majorly big deals, 5 cr, 8 cr, 10 cr kind of clients, but the problem is that it takes a very long time from us. I lost two multi-million clients. They verbally told me the next deal is going to go to a different bank. We are losing big way and we don't know what is the magnitude of that. Their references and friends will say "instead of Axis" when they're using other bank in their discussion..."*

*- AVP, Abu Dhabi*

# Digital Experience at Stage IV

| PRODUCT | AXIS BANK | COMPETITOR BANK |
|---|---|---|
| **FCNR** | A cumbersome offline process via Indian branches with high TAT. | ICICI's centralised SWIFT code, IndusInd's customer-ID-triggered auto-FD, IDFC's smoothness. |
| **REPATRIATION (NRO → NRE)** | Requires physical forms and manual compliance checks that take up to 3 weeks. | ICICI allows digital document uploads and clear transfers within 1-2 days. |
| **OTHERS** | Missing PIS Accounts for "Burgundy Private" clients cannot via IB, despite this feature being available for lower-tier Priority clients. | IndusInd's funds-pulling option allows users to quickly 'pull' in money from accounts at different banks rather than transfer from separate apps. |

*"...So in IndusInd bank they say you send the money and it is being centralised. We also have done that but it is only for the admin purpose only for the opening perspective but in terms of using the branch account it is the same old story..."*

*- AVP, Dubai*

# The HNI Experience

Users at this stage are HNIs. At Axis Bank, the self-serve limit control is a genuine differentiator for retail and mass-affluent NRI users. But **HNIs' multi-million transfer needs hit the ceiling against these mobile banking limits.**

*"...limit increase option in ICICI is you know quite fast, within a second it gets increased up to 1 crores a day and internal transfer is not counted in the daily limit..."*

*- Senior Manager, Abu Dhabi*

**Other experience challenges for the HNI segment**

- **Lack of UI differentiation**
  - There's no visual change from standard accounts for this segment.
- **Lack of Priority Service line**
  - "Burgundy Private" clients are subjected to the exact same sluggish queues, rate approval procedures, and delayed SR processing as standard "Prime" customers.
  - There is no automated, priority service line for HNIs, which embarrasses the ROs managing these multi-million dollar portfolios.

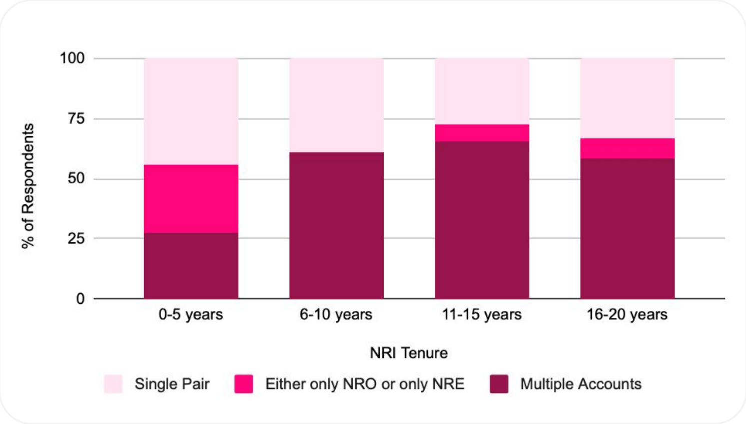
*"...We have a Burgundy Private team, but they don't have a separate service line. A Burgundy Private customer transferring $50,000 gets the same rate approval procedure as a basic customer. Burgundy customers go through the same queue as a prime customer. Nothing is automatic..."*

*- AVP, Abu Dhabi*

# Stage V: Consolidation (and exit)

NRI users can gather multiple accounts across different banks as their product usage expands. This multi-account network also serves as a safety net against system outages and strict compliance lockouts.

**Over time managing multiple accounts can become difficult and maintaining multiple MABs seems a poor financial decision. Relationship closures are often driven by user repatriation and users wanting to consolidate their finances.**




NUMBER OF NRI ACCOUNTS HELD

**MAB Struggles of lower-income strata**

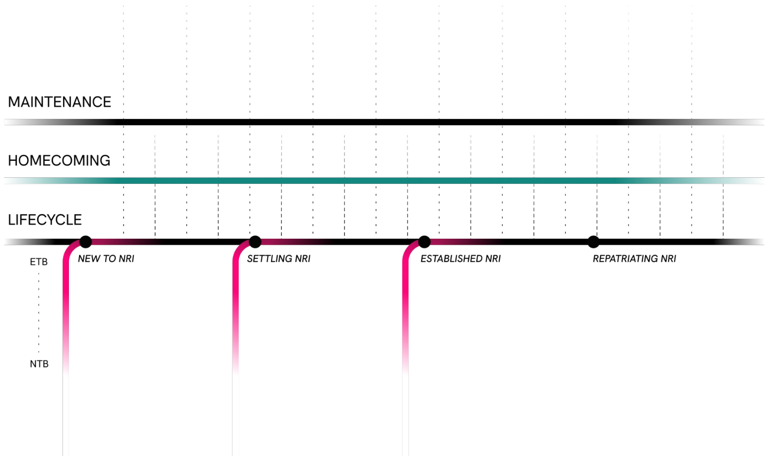
- This segment often finds it difficult to maintain even a INR 25,000 minimum average balance and strongly prefers zero-balance accounts so they can remit every available rupee to their families. This can become the reason for exiting the bank.

# The Homecoming Loop

# The Homecoming Loop

The homecoming loop is a cross-cutting experience in the NRI Lifecycle. Every trip to India triggers a temporary shift in payment trails, card handling, and cash management.

While a particular digital financial behavior is **"loading" the NRO account right before traveling to India**, users might **miss carrying physical products** like chequebook, welcome kits and may face issues in managing money in India.




*"...Earlier days they used to have the issues of mobile app number change. We cannot access the you know mobile application from there and all. But after this PhonePe comes you know everything is easy for them for doing the transactions wherever they are they are able to do it..."*

*- Senior Manager, Abu Dhabi*

# The Homecoming Loop: User Behaviour

When in India, usage of NRI accounts is primarily to fund transactions that are done via UPI or Debit cards.

- **Usage of UPI**
  - Customers without dual or Esims tend not to keep their UAE numbers on roaming. Instead they swap to an Indian SIM card which often disconnects them from their account access.
  - However, UPI mode is rampant for handling spends in India especially via PhonePe due to its compatibility with UAE numbers.

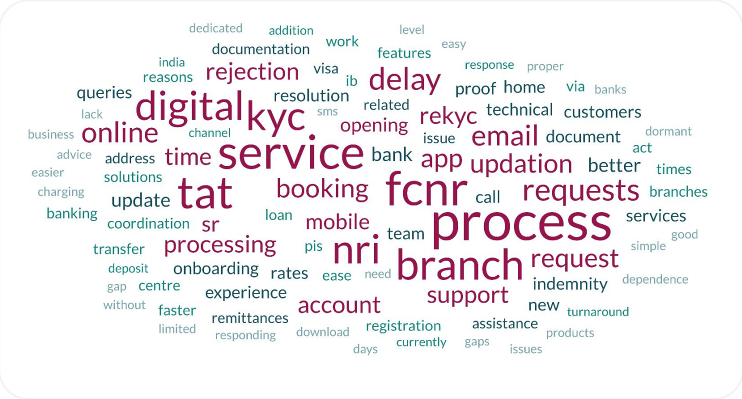
- **Usage of debit cards**
  - Debit cards are another alternative and users who prefer this mode often setup/ manage their card limits/ controls when travelling to India.
  - Post the capability of CVV for card management, the DCN option is redundant and needs to be removed from the digital channels to avoid confusing users.
  - Debit cards applied at Indian branches get delivered to the UAE address as per address details leaving the user with no card to use during homecoming.

# The Maintenance Loop

# The Maintenance Loop

The Maintenance Loop is also a cross cutting experience that resurfaces every 1–3 years regardless of which stage the user is otherwise in.

**The app's maturity looks concentrated on core transactional flows, not on the lower-frequency periphery.** It handles everyday tasks (checking balances, simple transfers, standard FD bookings) seamlessly. But **the moment a user attempts an administrative, compliance, or updation task the workflows break down.**




**The gaps in NRI Banking at Axis Bank according to the survey respondents.**

# Effects of User Behaviour 1/2

**Low frequency usage and security concerns leave NRI banking channels dormant, creating critical access barriers, especially during financial emergencies.**

- **NRI Banking is a secondary relationship**
  - For most NRIs, NRI Banking is a secondary, low-frequency use case by design. Local banks handle daily life abroad, and the Indian account exists for savings, remittance, or investment.
- **Mobile Banking is perceived as less secure**
  - Despite the push for mobile banking, a significant portion of customers (especially older millennials and HNIs) actively avoid it due to a perceived lack of security influenced by rampant scams.
  - Users unaware of alternatives can get locked out of IB login due to its dependency on mobile app code.
- **These two lead to the inability to maintain both digital channels**
  - The practical cost of this consequence shows up during urgencies; the customer first has to activate a unused channel and face login delays if they have forgotten passwords or they have to register afresh.

*"...suppose customer wants to transfer 1 cr rupees but client limit is suppose 50 lakhs in the system. If he increases also it takes time because if he forgot the password of the app or reset it, the limit resets for 24 hours the they get message your internet bank limit is 50,000 for 24 hours after that it will be renewed...now in that case there is no option customer has to call us they have to transfer urgently there is no option so in that case we have to go and do the take the RTGS or any form and get it and through service request..."*

*- Senior Manager, Dubai*

# Effects of User Behaviour 2/2

**Alert fatigue from excessive marketing spam causes customers to miss critical compliance warnings, resulting in unexpected account freezes and frustrated requests for urgent support.**

- **Users bombarded with extensive communications**
  - Users are overwhelmed by the sheer volume of banking communications, leading to a dangerous habit of ignoring all notifications, including critical compliance warnings.
- **Priority notifications lost in the noise**
  - Because priority alerts are drowned out by marketing spam, users instinctively delete or ignore banking emails.
- **These two lead to user being late to realise their account & compliance status**
  - As a result of ignoring these nudges, customers only realise their account status (KYC or account dormancy) after their account is frozen or a transaction (like a loan EMI) fails, leading to urgent, frustrated requests for fast resolutions.

*"...To be frank, all banks are sending multiple emails...awareness, KYC, products. If a customer has three banks, that's 30 emails just for banking. When you add UAE banks and alerts/OTPs, it's closely 40-50 alerts. People tend to take it easy and miss it, then they get locked.*
*I'm not even adding transaction alerts where OTP comes in where transaction confirmation comes in..."*

*- AVP, Abu Dhabi*

# The Maintenance Loop (User's Experience)

Maintenance options available digitally mis-function → Freeze first strategy and users locked out of digital channels → Maintenance shifts offline → Slow, invisible processing → Increased load on ROs to coordinate backend while managing users

*"...last week one of my customer her marriage is this 26 and she want to change the mobile number because company provided the number and that sim got disabled. She cannot use the funds for her marriage due to the mobile number issue and due to the new restriction she cannot take the request from here. So I suggested the email indemnity process and I have guided still she didn't receive the email for doing the e-sign part. It's around 12 working days. The email indemnity option is good but it should be faster...."*

*- Assistant Manager, Dubai*

*"...we we will be the first facing point. So they show all the all irritation to us and we have to take it up. Also if something is not working then only we can give the the contact details of the branches because we don't want them to get bombarded with the customer anger so we try to handle things from ourselves uh maximum to in our place itself but when the branches are not supporting then we are left with no option we have to give the customer the branch details...."*

*- Senior Manager, Dubai*

# The Maintenance Loop: App Level 1/2

Broken UI elements (without explanation) affect maintenance tasks and shift reliance to manual branch support.

- **Disabled Interactions**
  - Critical compliance actions, like the "update visa" upload button, are frequently disabled with no clear explanation, preventing users from completing required updates.

- **Basic account-lifecycle actions are are unavailable and users have to rely on offline processes that are slow.**
  - Updating phone numbers,
  - Updating email
  - Downgrading accounts
  - Reactivating dormant accounts

*"...Even though the KYC is complete, if the visa expires, clients get a pop-up stating they will only be allowed five transactions if they don't update it within the timeline. It's a perfect thing to give clear information, but when the client goes to the visa update option, the upload option is often disabled..."*

*- Senior Manager, Dubai*

*"...some options available in ICICI or IDFC app there are some features they suggest you know it is is drawn there which is one is phone number updation, dormant account activation..."*

*- Manager, Sharjah*

# The Maintenance Loop: App Level 2/2

**The app moves faster than the task allows.** Task flows are frequently too long, repetitive, or demand unnecessary manual effort from the user.

- **Redundant Data Entry**
  - When users upload identity documents (like passports), users have to manually type in details already available in the upload.
- **Timeout Windows**
  - Adding such details manually takes time but the session ends by the time users can finish cross-checking the data.

*"...when we upload the document all the data you know expiry date, issue date, everything should get captured automatically but all these things they have to type manually. So there are customers who have come that we have already attached the picture while you want us to fill up these details...and it takes time to type all of that..customer will check if they have written correctly. By that time he will then see screen has timed out...not all people can type that fast..."*

*- Senior Manager, Abu Dhabi*

# The Maintenance Loop: Product Level

**The bank's approach to account maintenance and compliance is reactive** and punitive, often freezing accounts without offering immediate digital recovery options.

- **The "Freeze First" Visa Strategy**
  - Customers are often notified after their visa has expired and they are subjected to a debit freeze after five transactions.
  - Once frozen, the system prevents the customer from digitally uploading the new visa, forcing them to contact a branch instead.
  - Moreover, the freeze and compliance mechanism doesn't leave room for real-world timelines failing to acknowledge that government visa renewals take time.
- **Misaligned requirements**
  - The back office demands high-clarity, color, dual-sided documents but the system imposes tiny file size limits (e.g., 200 KB).
  - Less tech-savvy customers are incapable of compressing high-res 1 MB PDFs down to 200 KB without losing clarity, creating a frustrating bottleneck.

*"...now you guys are recently giving a pop-up my visa is expired; right beautiful option! give me a pop-up 2 months before or one month before, ICICI is giving this option here they they're sending emails as well as the popup in mobile app 'you are not using your XYZ account from the last so and so days please make it active'..."*

*- Senior Manager, Dubai*

# The Maintenance Loop: Service Level 1/3

The most prominent pain point is the **slow backend processing time for Service Requests (SRs)**, which operates in stark contrast to the urgent needs of the customers and the standards set by competitor banks. It **often completely disconnects users from their funds.**

- **The Long Limbo**
  - Whether a customer submits ReKYC, a Visa update, or an Email Indemnity request, the current TAT is around 10 to 18 days.
- **The Linear Lockout**
  - During this processing window, customers are entirely locked out of submitting alternative requests. If an SR is pending for 20 days, the customer cannot make a new request or course-correct.
- **Silent Rejections**
  - When an SR is finally processed and rejected, users do not receive its reason. The link is frequently broken or invalid and users have to again fallback on the Rep-Office staff for aid.

*"...Yesterday we have seen a case last month 20th he had made a uh request still it is pending only but in this time duration they cannot raise another request they cannot you know do anything else. So that makes the customer to get frustrated..."*

*- Senior Manager, Abu Dhabi*

*"...When the service request gets rejected, the client gets an email stating the SR has been closed, but the reason is not specified. There is a link which says "click here to know the reason," but when the client clicks, it often shows as an invalid web link or doesn't show the reason..."*

*- Senior Manager, Abu Dhabi*

# The Maintenance Loop: Service Level 2/3

The combination of **unreasonable TAT and rigid compliance systems** results in automated account freezes. This **shifts a massive, manual burden onto the Rep Office (RO) employees.**

*“...verification of documents it should be online here. Now attestation is very difficult from here...”*
*- Assistant Manager, Dubai*

**Manual Cost of Compliance**

- When customers delay KYC or Visa updates past the deadline, their accounts automatically freeze, completely blocking all digital channels.
- Hence the Rep Office employees must physically travel to collect manual forms and wet signatures. In the sprawling UAE geography, visiting just two customers can consume an employee's entire half-day.
- Frequent changes to the UI layout mean that features are constantly moving, forcing staff to spend 5-10 minutes just locating basic features for clients.

*“...also there are some set of requests that is not possible through the mobile app or net banking where we have to go and collect forms and get it signed by the customer and then we have to coordinate with the branches in India and get it done....”*

*- Senior Manager, Dubai*

# The Maintenance Loop: Service Level 3/3

Employees stationed in the UAE (Rep Offices) rely heavily on Indian branches to execute manual and backend processes. However, this **dependency is failing due to an assumed lack of standardisation and training in India.**

- **Lack of standardisation**
  - Rep Office staff shares that there is no uniform process across clusters. For example, during outward remittances, one branch might require an original physical form, while another will process it via a scanned copy.
- **Potential Staff Shortage**
  - They are frequently met with excuses about staff shortages or new employees who simply do not know the process. For instance, booking an FCNR becomes chaotic because branch staff often don't even know their own SLFC (parking account) number, or the account is dormant and requires activation first.
- **Frequent Unresponsiveness**
  - Indian branches and RMs are often unresponsive to both customers and Rep Office employees which then requires escalation to supervisors.

*"… In almost all the cases without supervisors involvement, it's like whenever I want to just for a visa updation how many follow-ups I did I don't know. So this kind of pretty simple things other banks are doing within one or two working days. We are doing it in seven or eight working days…."*

*- Assistant Manager, Dubai*

# Case Study: ReKYC

# ReKYC Case Study



**Session timeout due to user unreadiness and manual data entry efforts**

Users are often unprepared with prerequisites when starting the process. The session can timeout if users spend time assimilating the required documents.

This is worsened by the manual inputs as session runs faster than users can input details and ensure they meet format/size restrictions.

**Progress loss from timeout creates frustration**

Unlike peer banks (like ICICI) that allow users to resume from the exact step where they left off, the Axis Bank system needs users to start the entire 5-6 step process over from the beginning if a timeout occurs.

**Localisation errors, financial jargon, and misaligned process creates confusion**

Form fields demand India-centric inputs ask for a "Pin Code" instead of a "PO Box" that's available for UAE users. UAE tenancy contracts also often lack the precise formatting the backend team expects for address details which leads to rejection.

During FATCA users incorrectly agree to being "tax resident of India." simply because they hold a PAN card, completely misunderstanding the legal definition of tax residency.

The front-end allows a user to submit their ReKYC without any option to upload Visa. However, the back-end team rejects the request explicitly because the Visa is expired.

# ReKYC Case Study



**Slow processing and lack of course correction causes unreasonable delays**

Since the past few months, the TAT for processing KYC has gone up from the stated 3-5 working days to almost 15-16, or even upwards of 20 days.

Because users often delay such updations until the last minute, the excessive processing times result in accounts being frozen, blocking access to funds. Users then escalate to Rep Office staff for immediate resolution.

Users face a linear lockout as they cannot edit any details till the current SR is closed. Rejected SRs do not provide reasons leaving user confused on next steps.

# ReKYC Case Study: Competitor Experience 4/4

**Contextual Deep-Linking for Rejections**
ICICI Bank includes a specific, deep-linked URL in their rejection emails that takes the customer directly to the specific step they failed (e.g., re-uploading just the Visa), rather than forcing them to repeat the entire journey.

**Email-Based Authenticated Links**
Local UAE banks (like Dubai Islamic Bank) bypass app logins entirely. They send a secure, time-bound link (valid for 15–21 days) via email. The link authenticates the user via OTP and allows them to quickly upload documents on a single webpage, which is perceived as far more streamlined and less error-prone.

*"... doing KYC in Axis bank is a task; the form is really big in terms of offline. KYC in Kotak, what I know last time when KYC was due, they gave a one page form single form...single means basic details name and everything and KYC was done in whatever time so in terms of I think they are handling the KYC processes better than us that I can say in product ours is a more lengthy process..."*

*- Senior Manager, Dubai*

# Executive Summary

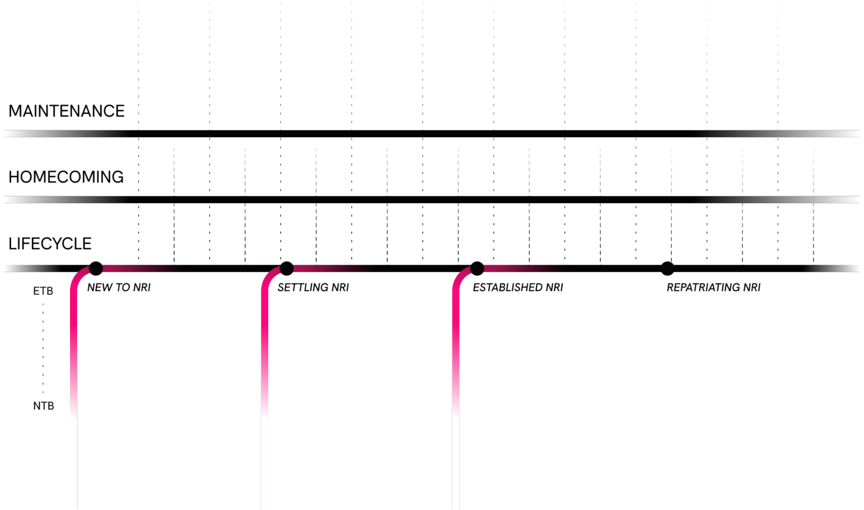
*Insights have been derived from second-hand accounts about users from the Representative Office staff. The geographical scope was also limited to the UAE (Abu Dhabi, Dubai, Sharjah).*

# Executive Summary



The NRI lifecycle is not just a person's journey from becoming an NRI to eventually leaving and repatriating to India but it also includes a recurring 'Maintenance' and 'Homecoming' loop throughout their tenure as an NRI.

Financial priorities shift predictably across this lifecycle.



# Executive Summary



| Archetypes → | New To NRI | Settling NRI | Established NRI | Repatriating NRI |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Profile** | Often younger in age and hence highly tech-savvy but they might not be banking-savvy. | A mix of upcoming HNIs and Blue-Collar members. | Often HNIs and could be arriving cusp of seniority. | Often HNIs and senior citizens. |
| **Goal** | To familiarise and restructure financial footprint as per guidelines. | To close pending liabilities asap and begin wealth accumulation. | To diversify wealth. | To streamline finances to reduce maintenance efforts. |
| **Behaviour** | Tend to enquire extensively in the initial months. | Tend to expect preferential treatment due to NRI status. | Tend to connect with multiple banks for best offerings as per goal. | Tend to consolidate finances and close relationships no longer needed. |

# Executive Summary



**Their banking is not just dual-geography but also compartmentalised across multiple banks.**

Local banks run daily life (receiving salary, bills, payments), whereas Indian accounts remain secondary, intermittent, purpose-built relations (investments, Indian expenses). In the UAE, remittance is preferred via local banks due to competitive conversion margins.

Further tertiary accounts are created with best products (across competitors) during wealth accumulation and diversification.

**Low income segments like blue-collar members are an anomaly to this pattern.**

Their primary focus is to actively support their family in India. They often hand over debit cards to families and primarily just need to track the balance and transactions.

This routine, along with tech constraints (like data-packs used) and language barriers lead to a preference for Whatsapp Banking.

# Executive Summary



**While the multi-banking network becomes a safety-net against system outages, it amplifies the 'maintenance loop' needing NRIs to keep up with the servicing needs of all their different accounts across banks.**

Additionally preferences (like trusting IB more than MB due to fear of scams, especially among the older cohort) means **both digital channels are not equally maintained to be active. This hinders dependencies and access during emergency.**

*"... in India people have one account with one bank and that doesn't get dormant because something or the other transactions keep on happening...but here people open additional accounts...I don't require another account but still I have another account maybe if I get an income in India maybe if I get a tax refund in India which is once in a year so that..."*
*- AVP, Dubai*

*"...because of all the scams happening they have got that kind that of thing in their mind that net banking is more safer when it comes to mobile banking. So they are not ready to use app. So in that also we have to again get back to our team for changing that mobile OTP...."*
*- Senior Manager, Abu Dhabi*

# *Executive Summary*



**At Axis Bank, the digital experience is strong where it has been most iterated on i.e. consolidated dashboard, self-service control, routine transactions once a customer is established.**

**But getting to this stable state is a hurdle.** There's a need for improvement at the lower-frequency but higher-stakes moments

- getting onboarded
- maintaining or updating an account
- moving money across borders

**While the dashboard's consolidated view works perfectly, there's a need to think about NRI usage beyond that to align with their intermittent needs.**

**Overall, localisation needs a hygiene check**

- PO box instead of Pincode
- Country codes during beneficiary

# Snapshot: The Axis Bank NRI Experience

| STATUS | PRODUCT | APP | SERVICE |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Working well** | **Robust Core Foundation**<br>Strong depth in traditional savings and high self-service transaction limits that empower mass-affluent users. | **Post-Onboarding Efficiency**<br>A seamless, highly reliable, and empowering interface for routine transactions and account visibility once the user is successfully onboarded. | **Relationship-Driven Trust**<br>High regional brand trust anchored by the willingness of local Rep Office staff to provide dedicated, hands-on support. |
| **Needs Improvement** | **Digital Gaps & Punitive Rules**<br>A lack of digital capabilities for basic updations & high-value tasks (FCNR, repatriation) coupled with rigid, context-blind compliance policies. | **Generic UX & Structural Friction**<br>Onboarding friction, one-for-all experience, and confusing information architecture after dashboard. | **Broken Backend Operations**<br>Paralyzing processing times, opaque resolutions, and inconsistent inter-branch coordination that shift massive, unnecessary manual burdens onto frontline staff. |

# Executive Summary



**The largest returns are likely to come from closing the gap at the edges where product, service, and app limitations currently reinforce one another.**

| Areas → | Getting Onboarded | Maintaining or updating an account | Moving money across borders |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Improvements** | SIM binding process requires informed guidance<br><br>The sequence of consent and registration needs to align with user's mental model<br><br>Workaround for dependents that do not have valid address proof | Provision of basic updations (mobile, email, dormancy) via digital channels<br><br>Preemptive, contextual communication to support user for timely completion of Visa, KYC updation. Account for real-world timelines like government dependencies to procure/ process documents<br><br>Reasonable and visible processing of SRs to reduce TAT, and load on frontline staff | Provision of FCNR booking, and NRO to NRE repatriation via digital channels with quicker and simpler processes |

# Thank You

# Executive Summary



**The "Spam to Freeze" Loop**

**Marketing practices directly cause critical compliance failures.**

Users receive a high volume of mixed communications from all the banks they are associated with.

→

Users develop "communication fatigue" and ignore, delete, or mute all bank emails.

→

Users completely miss critical deadlines for ReKYC or Visa updates.

→

The compliance system triggers a "freeze-first" protocol, locking the user's account & transactions.

→

Users panic over losing access to their funds and aggressively demand immediate support from frontline staff.

# Executive Summary



**The Compliance & Manual Burden Cascade**
**Rigid digital rules cripple employee productivity**

Compliance failure locks the user's account and with it, also access to uploading new documents.

→

Users have no self-service digital recovery options.

→

The burden of resolution shifts entirely to the frontline service staff who even have to travel to users.

→

Due to geographic scope, staff completes just two visits a day, drastically reducing operational efficiency and increasing employee frustration.

# Executive Summary



**The Backend Blackhole & Customer Paralysis**
**Backend operations cause real-world financial anxiety**

Backend teams operate with unreasonable TAT of 10 to 20 days and users cannot re-submit till the pending request is closed.

→

Customers are paralysed as they cannot use their accounts, course-correct errors, or submit alternative requests for weeks.

→

Rejected requests give no reasons, forcing the user to blindly restart the 15-day waiting period.

→

Users might be unable to access funds for urgencies.

Or the TAT of one process affects another compliance (visa gets expired by the time a SR is processed, requiring users to initiate another one.